

Programming Languages Notes

CG

May 1, 2026

1 Abstract syntax trees

An *abstract syntax tree* (AST) is a tree representation of the hierarchical structure of a program. Unlike a concrete parse tree, an AST omits purely syntactic detail such as parenthesis, semicolons used as separators, keywords whose meaning is already captured by the node type; retaining only the information needed to define the program's meaning.

Each *internal node* of the AST corresponds to a language construct (sequence, assignment, conditional, etc.) and each *leaf* corresponds to an atomic value or reference.

For an imperative language with mutable references, the relevant constructs are:

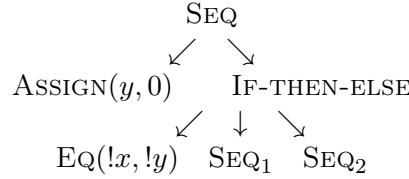
- $C_1 ; C_2$, sequential composition
- $l := e$, assignment to location l
- **if** B **then** C_1 **else** C_2 , conditional command
- **while** B **do** C , iteration
- $!l$, dereferencing a location (read the value stored at l)
- n, b , integer and boolean literals
- $e_1 \text{ op } e_2$, arithmetic or boolean combination

1.1 solved example

Build the AST of the following program:

```
 $y := 0 ; \text{ if } !x = !y \text{ then } x := !x + 1 ; y := !y - 1 \text{ else } x := !x - 1 ; y := !y + 1$ 
```

The top level operator is the semicolon that separates the two main components, so the root is a SEQ node. Its left child is the assignment $y := 0$, and its right child is the conditional. The conditional has three children: the guard $!x = !y$, the *then*-branch $x := !x + 1 ; y := !y - 1$, and the *else*-branch (symmetric).



note that $!x$ is represented as a Deref node applied to the location x , which is distinct from x as an identifier: the location names a cell in the store, and dereferencing reads its content.

1.2 Exercises

- Build the AST of: $x := !x \times 2 ; \text{if } !x > 10 \text{ then skip else } x := !x + 1$
- Build the AST of: **while** $!i < !n$ **do** $s := !s + !i ; i := !i + 1$
- Reconstruct the source program corresponding to the following AST:
root is SEQ with left child ASSIGN($x, 5$) and right child IF-THEN-ELSE(EQ($!x, 5$), ASSIGN($y, 1$), ASS

2 Type inference

Type inference is the process by which a compiler deduces the type of an expression without explicit annotations from the programmer. the classical algorithm for the simply typed lambda calculus (and its extensions) is *Hindley Milner* (HM), which works by:

1. Assigning a fresh type variable α_i to each sub-expression whose type is unknown.
2. Generating *constraints* of the form $\tau_1 = \tau_2$ from the typing rules.
3. Solving the constraints by *unification*.

if unification fails, the program contains a type error; if it succeeds, the resulting substitution gives the most general type.

2.1 Typing rules for references

$\frac{\text{T-DEREF} \quad \Gamma \vdash !l : T}{\Gamma \vdash l : \text{ref } T}$	$\frac{\text{T-ASSIGN} \quad \Gamma \vdash l := e : \text{unit}}{\Gamma \vdash l : \text{ref } T \quad \Gamma \vdash e : T}$	$\frac{\text{T-WHILE} \quad \Gamma \vdash \text{while } B \text{ do } C : \text{unit}}{\Gamma \vdash B : \text{bool} \quad \Gamma \vdash C : \text{unit}}$
---	--	--

2.2 solved example

$\lambda f. f f$ does not typecheck

Consider `proc(f) zero?((f f))`. We try to infer the type of f .

- Let $f : \alpha$.
- The expression $f f$ requires f to be a function type, so $\alpha = \alpha \rightarrow \beta$ for some fresh β .
- But $\alpha = \alpha \rightarrow \beta$ has no finite solution: expanding repeatedly yields $\alpha = (\alpha \rightarrow \beta) \rightarrow \beta = ((\alpha \rightarrow \beta) \rightarrow \beta) \rightarrow \beta = \dots$

unification fails (occurs check). Therefore the expression has no type in the simply typed lambda calculus without recursive types.

2.3 Scala generics

```
case class MyPair[A,B](x:A,y:B)
val p = MyPair(1, "Scala")
def id[T](x:T)=x
val q = id(1)
```

the definition of `id` introduces a **polymorphic** type: it can be applied to any type, and each call site independently instantiates a T .

```
B = !n < 5
B1 = !term <= 2
C1 = res := !n
C2 = c:=!a+!b; res:=!n; !c; a:=!b; b:=!c
C = if B1 then C1 else C2; n:=!n+1
a:=1; b:=1; while B do C
```

reading off types from the operations performed:

- $n, res, a, b, c : \text{ref int}$ (assigned integers and dereferenced in arithmetic).
- $term : \text{ref int}$ (compared with 2).

- $B, B_1 : \mathbf{bool}$.
- $C_1, C_2, C : \mathbf{unit}$ (commands produce no value).
- The whole program : **unit**.

2.4 Exercises

Infer the type of the S combinator: $\lambda x. \lambda y. \lambda z. x z (y z)$. What constraints does unification generate?

Consider $\lambda f. \lambda x. f (f x)$. Does it typecheck? If so, give its most general type.

What types are inferred for **f**, **result**, and **pairs** in the following Scala snippet?

```
def f[A](lst: List[A]) = lst.head
val result = f(List(1,2,3))
val pairs  = List((1,"a"), (2,"b"))
```

Given $x : \mathbf{ref\ int}$ and $b : \mathbf{ref\ bool}$, does the following expression type-check? If so, give its type.

$b := !x = 0 ; \mathbf{if\ !b\ then\ } x := 1 \mathbf{\ else\ skip}$

3 Operational semantics

3.1 Big-step semantics

In *big-step* (natural semantics, a judgement) $\langle e, \sigma \rangle \Downarrow v$ asserts that expression e in store σ evaluates *directly* to value v , without exposing intermediate steps. Derivations are trees whose leaves are axioms and whose internal nodes are inference rules.

3.1.1 Lists: concat and append

We assume the constructors **nil** (empty list) and **cons**(h, t) (list with head h and tail t).

concat(e, ℓ), **insert element** e **at the end of** ℓ .

$$\frac{\text{CONCAT-NIL} \quad \langle \mathbf{concat}(e, \mathbf{nil}), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \mathbf{cons}(e, \mathbf{nil}) \quad \text{CONCAT-CONS} \quad \langle \mathbf{concat}(e, \mathbf{cons}(h, t)), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \mathbf{cons}(h, t')}{\langle \mathbf{concat}(e, t), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow t'}$$

$\text{append}(\ell_1, \ell_2)$ concatenate two lists.

$$\frac{\text{APPEND-NIL} \quad \langle \text{append}(\text{nil}, \ell_2), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \ell_2 \quad \text{APPEND-CONS} \quad \frac{\langle \text{append}(\text{cons}(h, t_1), \ell_2), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \text{cons}(h, \ell')}{\langle \text{append}(t_1, \ell_2), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \ell'}}{\langle \text{append}(\text{nil}, \ell_2), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \ell_2}$$

Derivation for append We verify $\langle \text{append}(\text{cons}(1, \text{nil}), \text{cons}(2, \text{nil})), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \text{cons}(1, \text{cons}(2, \text{nil}))$:

$$\frac{\text{APPEND-CONS} \quad \langle \text{append}(\text{cons}(1, \text{nil}), \text{cons}(2, \text{nil})), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \text{cons}(1, \text{cons}(2, \text{nil}))}{\text{APPEND-NIL} \quad \langle \text{append}(\text{nil}, \text{cons}(2, \text{nil})), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \text{cons}(2, \text{nil})}$$

3.2 Small-step semantics

In *small-step* semantics, a judgement $\langle P, \sigma \rangle \rightarrow \langle P', \sigma' \rangle$ performs a single atomic reduction. A program is fully evaluated when no rule applies (it is a value or a stuck state) or when it reduces to **skip** (for commands).

3.2.1 For-loops in SIMP

The grammar of SIMP extended with **for** is:

$$C ::= l := E \mid C ; C \mid \text{if } B \text{ then } C \text{ else } C \mid \text{while } B \text{ do } C \mid \text{skip} \mid \text{for } (C; B; C) \{C\}$$

The cleanest approach is to treat **for** as *syntactic sugar*:

$$\text{for } (C_i; B; C_s) \{C_b\} \triangleq C_i ; \text{while } B \text{ do } C_b ; C_s$$

If the language requires explicit small-step rules (no sugar), we give:

$$\frac{\text{FOR-INIT} \quad \langle \text{for } (C_i; B; C_s) \{C_b\}, \sigma \rangle \rightarrow \langle \text{for } (C'_i; B; C_s) \{C_b\}, \sigma' \rangle}{\langle C_i, \sigma \rangle \rightarrow \langle C'_i, \sigma' \rangle}$$

FOR-SKIP

$$\langle \text{for } (\text{skip}; B; C_s) \{C_b\}, \sigma \rangle \rightarrow \langle \text{if } B \text{ then } (C_b; C_s; \text{for } (\text{skip}; B; C_s) \{C_b\}) \text{ else skip}, \sigma \rangle$$

Rule FOR-INIT reduces the initialiser one step at a time. Rule FOR-SKIP fires once the initialiser has been fully executed: it checks the guard and either runs the body followed by the step expression (and loops), or terminates with **skip**.

3.3 Exercises

- Write big-step rules for **reverse**(ℓ), which reverses a list.
- Use **concat** as a helper.

Prove with a full derivation tree:

$$\langle \text{concat}(3, \text{cons}(1, \text{cons}(2, \text{nil}))), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow \text{cons}(1, \text{cons}(2, \text{cons}(3, \text{nil})))$$

- Write big-step rules for **length**(ℓ), which returns the number of elements, and evaluate $\langle \text{length}(\text{cons}(1, \text{cons}(2, \text{nil}))), \sigma \rangle \Downarrow 2$ with a derivation tree.

4 Lambda calculus

Language formalizations and its structure are successfully applied the logic of first order predicates with quantifiers. First of all, when the lambda calculus concept comes to be oriented in semantics representations, or either in programming language studies, the mechanisms are based on the meta-operations and functional abstraction.

4.1 example 1

We can take the phrase 'every athlete strives to victory' and consider its structure:

5 Type safety

6 Denotational semantics

7 Axiomatic semantics (Hoare logic)